



The Altiplano

A vast, high plateau of the central Andes with stunning, otherworldly scenery and harsh living conditions

Set against a backdrop of volcanoes, the Altiplano is a windswept landscape of sparsely vegetated high plains, lakes, and salt flats, occupying about 77,000 square miles (200,000 square km) of the central Andes. Much of it lies in Bolivia, but parts of it extend into Peru, Chile, and Argentina in the south. It contains one large urban area—the adjacent cities of La Paz and El Alto in Bolivia.

Land of fire, ice, salt, and wind

The Altiplano is bordered on the west by a subrange of the Andes, the Western Cordillera, which includes some massive volcanoes. The Altiplano is mostly arid, especially in the south, where the annual rainfall is only about 8 in (200 mm). It also has some large salt flats, such as the Salar de Uyuni (see p.126).

Because of the high altitude, the air is thin and the climate is quite harsh. Although temperatures during the day can reach 50–77°F (10–25°C), at night they plunge to as low as -4°F (-20°C) in the southern Altiplano. The local wildlife, which is adapted to these conditions, includes vicuñas (llama relatives), viscachas (rabbitlike rodents), and the Andean fox.



◀ PROTECTIVE COAT

The viscacha's thick, fine fur allows it to withstand year-round freezing nighttime temperatures.

The **average height** of the Altiplano is **12,300 ft (3,750 m)**



BENEATH THE ALTIPLANO

In the central Andes, two or more phases of mountain building pushed up the Eastern and Western Cordilleras, which are separated by the Altiplano. The details of how the Altiplano formed are fiercely debated, although recent research suggests that the crust under it was lifted about 2 miles (3 km) in a series of spurts in the last 25 million years.

